

Overjustification Effect

What is it?

External rewards can reduce a person's natural motivation to do something they already enjoy.

History

First demonstrated in motivational psychology research around **1973**, where studies showed that offering rewards for enjoyable tasks caused people to lose intrinsic interest in those tasks.

The Psychology Behind It

- Intrinsic motivation feels natural and personal
- External rewards shift focus away from enjoyment
- Activity starts to feel transactional
- Users begin valuing the reward more than the experience

Why It Matters

- Lower genuine engagement
- Decreased trust in product intention
- Inauthentic behavior increases
- Product or brand perception becomes weaker

How to Apply It

- Focus on meaning, mastery, and progress
- Offer surprise rewards, not constant transactional rewards
- Build genuine community and belonging
- Make the activity itself feel valuable and enjoyable

Theory in Action

- Duolingo's badge mechanics boosted referral activity by reinforcing achievements toward progress
- Cafes and bookstores use loyalty cards to add positive reinforcement without making the experience feel purely commercial

Final Thought

Rewards should enhance intrinsic motivation — not replace it.

When users value the journey more than the prize, long-term engagement grows naturally.

